

Why One Holiday Has Two Names

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On October 12, 2026, many Americans will mark a holiday. Some call it Columbus Day. Others call it **Indigenous** Peoples' Day.

Columbus Day honors Christopher Columbus, an **explorer** from Italy. He arrived in the Americas on October 12, 1492. But **Indigenous** peoples, including Native Americans, had already lived there for thousands of years. **Critics** say his arrival led to Native Americans being treated badly.

In 1977, Native American leaders suggested a new name: **Indigenous** Peoples' Day. In 1992, Berkeley, California, became the first city to use it. Now more than 100 cities and several states do. In 2021, President Joe Biden **officially** recognized the holiday.

Not everyone wants a new name. Many Italian Americans say Columbus Day celebrates Italian culture, not Columbus himself.

History can be **complicated**. No matter which name people use, the holiday is a time to think about the past.

Word Treasure

Indigenous -- Describing the first people who lived in a place.

explorer -- A person who travels to new places to learn about them.

Critics -- People who point out what they think is wrong with something.

officially -- In a formal way, by people in charge.

complicated -- Hard to understand because it has many parts.

Background you need

Christopher Columbus sailed across the Atlantic Ocean and reached the Americas, where many Native American nations already lived.

Today, people disagree about how to remember him, so one holiday has two names.

Break it down

WHO: Americans, Native American leaders and Italian Americans

WHAT: A holiday that some call Columbus Day and others call Indigenous Peoples' Day

WHERE: Across the United States, on October 12, 2026

WHY: People disagree about how to remember Columbus and the Indigenous peoples who already lived in the Americas

Why it matters

Kids may hear both names at school, and learning why helps them understand history from different points of view.

Test what you remember

1. On what date is the holiday this year?

- ☐ (A) January 1, 2027
- ☐ (B) July 4, 2026
- ☐ (C) November 26, 2026
- ☐ (D) October 12, 2026

2. Where was Christopher Columbus from?

- ☐ (A) Italy
- ☐ (B) Norway
- ☐ (C) Hawaii
- ☐ (D) Spain

3. When did Columbus arrive in the Americas?

- ☐ (A) 1977
- ☐ (B) 2021
- ☐ (C) 1992
- ☐ (D) October 12, 1492

4. Which city first used the name Indigenous Peoples' Day?

- ☐ (A) Berkeley, California
- ☐ (B) Miami, Florida
- ☐ (C) New York City
- ☐ (D) Rome, Italy

5. Which president officially recognized Indigenous Peoples' Day in 2021?

- ☐ (A) George Washington
- ☐ (B) Donald Trump
- ☐ (C) Abraham Lincoln
- ☐ (D) Joe Biden

6. What do many Italian Americans say Columbus Day celebrates?

- ☐ (A) Sports
- ☐ (B) The ocean
- ☐ (C) Pizza only
- ☐ (D) Italian culture

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: A 3: D 4: A 5: D 6: D

Questions to think about

1. Critics: Say Columbus's arrival led to Native Americans being treated badly.
2. Native American leaders: Suggested the new name Indigenous Peoples' Day.
3. Many Italian Americans: Say Columbus Day celebrates Italian culture, not Columbus himself.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):